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The pale fox

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Document Type: Book

Original Page: 26

Culture (OWC): [Dogon \(FA16\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

Field Date: 1931-1956

Coverage Date: Not Specified

Place Coverage: Bandiagara Escarpment, Mali

Section Title(S): Untitled Section

The wild fauna includes hyenas, panthers, foxes, monkeys, crocodiles, reptiles, snakes, etc. Game is comprised of birds, pigeons, partridges, ducks, etc., leporidae, and antelopes. The ponds or watering holes supply some fish during the dry season, especially siluridae.

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The sparse natural resources, animal and vegetable, are not sufficient to sustain the inhabitants.

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The subsoil contains iron and copper, once mined by local industry, and black marble used for making bracelets.

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Despite inexact census taking, due to emigration to large cities and to worsening conditions, one may estimate that nearly 250,000 Dogon inhabit Mali and Upper Volta. They constitute demographic agglomerations of widely varying importance, forming villages and small towns. Some groups of villages are connected and placed under the authority of a religious chief (Hogon).

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In the plain, the Dogon — who then occupy a neighborhood — sometimes live in symbiosis with the Mossi and Kouroumba, each group occupying a neighborhood of the same village. There are two similar situations in other regions with the Bambara or the Songhai. The Dogon, who are farmers, maintain special relations with the Bozo, fishermen of the Niger, which the Dogon call *sorogon*; they are united through a cathartic relationship or “joking kinship,” which implies the observance of a certain number of prohibitions and also mutual aid. both rigorously defined.

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Historically, the first inhabitants of the region seem to have been the Kouroumba, whom the Dogon call Tellem. They left many pise structures (dwellings, granaries, sanctuaries), particularly in the steep and most inaccessible walls of the cliffs; cemeteries, and also religious material, especially wooden statuettes of a remarkable esthetic quality.

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Prehistory

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